



Nikon D90

Expensive, but hard to resist!

One of the key attractions this month had to be the Nikon D90, which is also the costliest camera we've tested so far. Nikon has brought in the D90 to replace the trusted D80. The D80 was one of the best upper-entry level to mid-range cameras from Nikon. The D90 then has a lot to prove before it can earn its place.

Going through the D90's key features, it certainly looks impressive. The

The shape and size of the D90 is somewhat larger than the D60 we saw a few months back. It's a bit heavier than the D60 and also the D80 itself. The body is plastic, but feels extremely sturdy and the buttons are great as expected on any Nikon D-SLR.

The D90 now comes with a 3-inch screen that is incredibly vibrant and crisp. The other thing that makes the camera interesting is the inclusion of Live

tive buttons and rotating the jog dial. Shutter speed and aperture size have dedicated dials.

It's very difficult to criticise the D90 on quality as well. The 12.3-MP CMOS sensor does its job well. Photos turn out crisp across the entire aperture range. The lens isn't made for macro photography, so you'll have difficulty with up-close shots. Mind you, great close-ups can be shot by moving back and zooming into the target. Good depth of field can be achieved easily too. The flash is powerful and good enough for indoor photography every now and then.

The Auto mode works well along with the auto-focus feature. Focusing is instantaneous and there is no delay whatsoever. There are a few autofocus hiccups every now and then, but nothing that can't be fixed using the other auto-focusing bracket modes. As expected from any D-SLR, the manual mode gives you total control of the camera. You won't be disappointed with the D90, if you like to select a scenario preset either — a dial for doing that is present.

Another new feature hardly ever seen on D-SLRs is video recording. The D90 can capture up to 1280x720 resolution videos at 24 frames per second. What makes it even more special is that you can zoom and focus manually while shooting videos. The video quality is great and the frame rate quite stable but you will need to buy a fast SD/SDHC card for it.

We'd be lying if we said that we weren't impressed with the D90. It's filled

with surprises. The camera is incredibly simple to use, it has the performance, the features and is undoubtedly miles ahead of the D80 in every aspect. Nikon has yet another winner on its hands and we highly recommend this if you have a serious interest in photography and also the money. The D90 along with its lens is priced at a whopping Rs. 89,890. The body by itself can be bought for Rs. 69,950. This makes the D90 almost as costly as the D300. It makes better sense if you spend more and go for the D300 instead. Nikon's lens are known to be cheaper than some other brands, so buying just a body and then a good lens can also be a good move. If you don't need the Live View or the video recording or even the small changes Nikon has made, then the older D80 is a better buy, especially with its more wallet-friendly price.

Specifications

12.3 MP CMOS sensor, ISO Range: 200 - 3200, Shutter speed range: 1/4000th to 30 seconds, Nikkor DX 18-105mm VR lens, 3-inch screen, SD/SDHC complaint, Video recording up to 1280x720 pixels.

Contact: Nikon India Pvt Ltd
Phone No: 022-40925555
Website: www.nikon.co.in
Price: Rs 89,890 (with 18-100mm VR lens)

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Sony Ericsson W595

Shake that phone

Sony Ericsson has been naming its phones by their features, like the Cybershot or the Walkman range. They've just introduced the newest model — the W595, so let's take a look at it.

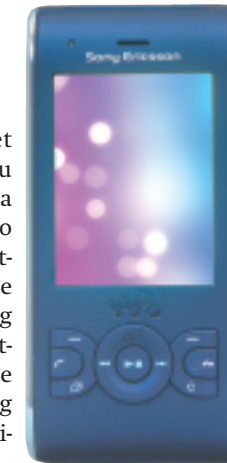
The W595 has a nice metallic steel border which gives it an oh-so-sleek look. There are stereo speakers at the top and bottom of the phone. The connection for USB and headphones for the phone is on the left, while the volume and the 'walkman' button is on the right. The phone feels pretty sturdy, but let's see if it really is.

Each of the buttons has a subtle, yet noticeable outline of a reflective turquoise blue colour. The distance between the buttons are

enough to get used to, but you need to put in a little effort into pushing the buttons to use the phone. Opening the back was a little troublesome with it refusing to come off easily.

This phone has features like YouTube streaming, RSS feed reader, Opera browser, but sadly no WiFi. Even so it has WAP, GPRS and EDGE support.

Many of the applications use the shake feature as an accelerometer. There is a bubble head wallpaper which on swaying the phone, moves in the opposite direction while bobbing. There is also an application called Walk



Mate, which is good for the fitness fanatics out there. The sound quality on the headphones is better than the speaker. The call quality is pretty decent and we had no issues with the reception.

However, there are a few drawbacks. The USB cable is too short and there is no 3.5-mm headphone jack. The shake-it features for switching between songs works fine, but the volume control seems a tad too sensitive. The slider is not very sturdy. We noticed there was a light at the corner of the keypad for illumination. It however, did not serve its purpose. Not all the buttons were illuminated.

We would not recommend that you buy this phone as it has some flaws that need to be corrected.

Specifications

Size: 1.9 x 3.9 x 0.6 inches, Weight: 104 g, Screen: 262k Colour QVGA, Resolution: 320x240, Memory: 40MB phone memory, expandable up to 8GB, Other: Bluetooth, WAP, GPRS, Wi-Fi, RSS reader, YouTube streaming

Contact: Sony Ericsson Mobile Communications India Pvt Ltd
Phone: 1800-11-1800
Email: questions.in@support.sonyericsson.com
Website: www.sonyericsson.com
Price: Rs 14,695

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Billion BiGuard 30

Guarding your networks

The Billion BiGuard 30 is a switch that is meant to be used as a security gateway. In comparison to some of the other network devices we've seen, this one is one of the nicer looking products. The front has status indication LEDs for all the eight LAN ports and another two for the WAN ports, all mounted on a glossy black surface. The rest of the body has a powder-coated paint finish.

The interface is simple to use, but isn't as colourful

and user-friendly as some home routers available today. The switch lets you connect to two external networks and data can be routed through them. This feature also allows load balancing between two connections. This is something very useful in SoHo scenarios. Setting up a WAN connection is easy and can be done using fixed IP addresses, PPPoE or two other methods.

Security is also taken care of with this device.

There are port blocking features put in place, and data can be monitored and blocked accurately. Web pages with some keywords can also be blocked. Virtual Private Networks can also be set up using this router. Intrusion detection mechanisms are present and logs for all kinds of events are maintained by the router. The router can be set up to send alerts by email. Using Dynamic DNS, the router can easily be accessed remotely.

The Billion makes perfect sense for SoHo users who have a small network. There are plenty of security features and the firmware allows very precise and accurate permissions and rules to be set. It is also the type

of switch and router that can be managed remotely.

At Rs 16,500, it's not very expensive for a SoHo especially for the function it performs.

Specifications

Two Ethernet WAN ports, eight Ethernet LAN ports, Dimensions: 482 x 166 x 42 mm

Contact: One Network (India) Pvt. Ltd
Phone: 9821014253
Email: deepak@onenetwork.co.in
Website: www.billion.com
Price: Rs 16,500

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★



D90 utilises a 12.3-MP CMOS sensor going up from the D80's 10.2-MP CCD sensor. The sensor size remains unchanged. Most entry-level cameras are supplied with an 18 to 55-mm lens which can be quite limiting to the kinds of photos you can take. We received the camera with a Nikkor DX 18 to 105-mm VR zoom lens. This makes a good all-purpose kit for wide-angle and telephoto shooting.

View that allows you to use the LCD screen to focus. This is a feature rarely found on D-SLRs.

The D90 is undoubtedly one of the easiest cameras to operate, if you have that a basic knowledge of using a decent point-and-shoot camera. All the functions of the camera such as ISO, white balance, exposure metering and focusing modes can be accessed by holding down the respec-